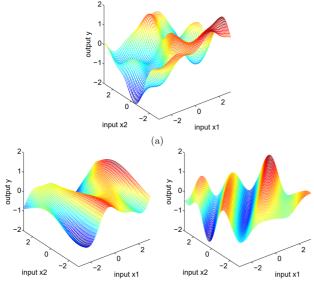
Introduction to Machine Learning

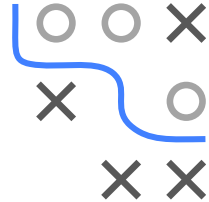
Gaussian Processes
Covariance functions for GPs



Learning goals

- Covariance functions encode key assumptions about the GP
- Know common covariance functions like squared exponential and Matérn

VALID COVARIANCE FUNCTIONS



- Recall marginalization property of GPs: for any $\boldsymbol{X} = \{\mathbf{x}^{(1)}, \ldots, \mathbf{x}^{(n)}\} \subset \mathcal{X}$,

$$\mathbf{f} = f(\boldsymbol{X}) \sim \mathcal{N}(\mathbf{m}, \mathbf{K})$$

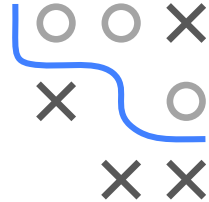
  with $\mathbf{m} = m(\boldsymbol{X})$, $\mathbf{K} = k(\boldsymbol{X}, \boldsymbol{X})$

- For $\mathbf{K}$ to be a valid cov matrix it needs to be positive semi-definite (PSD) for any choice of inputs $\boldsymbol{X}$

- Cov function (or kernel) determines cov matrix: $\mathbf{K} = k(\boldsymbol{X}, \boldsymbol{X})$

- Implication: only **PSD functions** (i.e., those that induce PSD $\mathbf{K}$) are valid cov functions ▸ Duvenaud 2014

STATIONARY COVARIANCE FUNCTIONS



- Recall concept of spatial correlation

$$\mathbf{x}, \tilde{\mathbf{x}} \text{ close in } \mathcal{X} \Rightarrow f(\mathbf{x}), f(\tilde{\mathbf{x}}) \text{ close in } \mathcal{Y}$$

- Measure "closeness" via $\boldsymbol{d} = \mathbf{x} - \tilde{\mathbf{x}}$

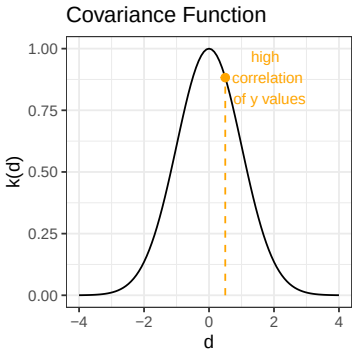
- $k(\cdot, \cdot)$ called **stationary** $\Leftrightarrow$ function of $\boldsymbol{d}$

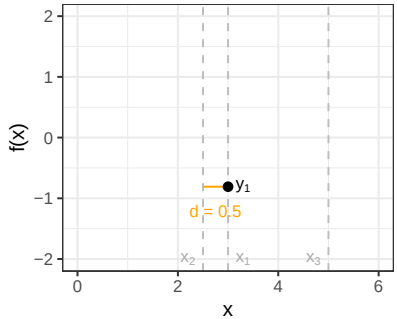
$$k(\mathbf{x}, \tilde{\mathbf{x}}) = k(\boldsymbol{d})$$

- Intuition: stationary $k(\cdot, \cdot)$ implies functions that vary smoothly regardless of where we are in input space

EXAMPLE: STATIONARY COVARIANCE

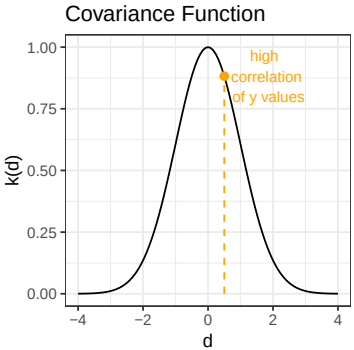
- Let $f \sim \mathcal{GP}(m(\cdot), k(\cdot,\cdot))$ with $k(\mathbf{x}, \tilde{\mathbf{x}}) = \exp(-\frac{1}{2}\|\boldsymbol{d}\|^2)$
- Consider two points $\mathbf{x}^{(1)} = 3$ and $\mathbf{x}^{(2)} = 2.5$
- If you want to know about the correlation between $f(\mathbf{x}^{(1)})$ and $f(\mathbf{x}^{(2)})$, compute $\boldsymbol{d}(\mathbf{x}^{(1)}, \mathbf{x}^{(2)})$

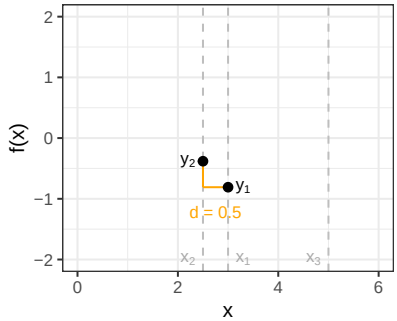




EXAMPLE: STATIONARY COVARIANCE

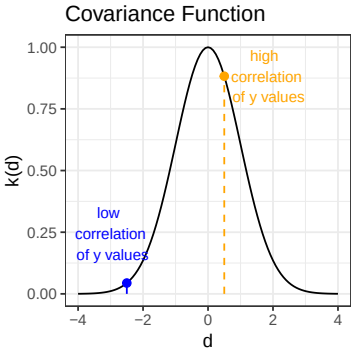
- Suppose we observe $y^{(1)} = -0.8$
- $\mathbf{x}^{(1)}, \mathbf{x}^{(2)}$ are close in $\mathcal{X}$ space
- Under the above GP assumption, $y^{(2)}$ should be close to $y^{(1)}$

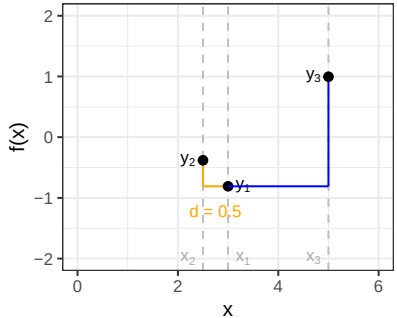




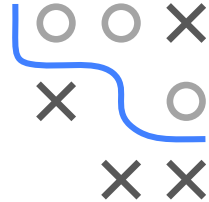
EXAMPLE: STATIONARY COVARIANCE

- Consider now $\mathbf{x}^{(3)} = 5$
- Further from $\mathbf{x}^{(1)} \Rightarrow$ expect lower correlation between $y^{(3)}$, $y^{(1)}$





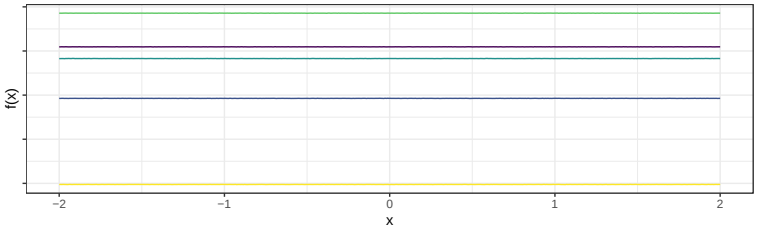
PROPERTIES OF COVARIANCE FUNCTIONS



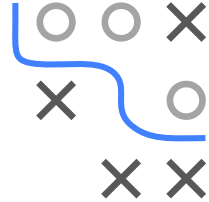
- Most cov functions belong to 3 common types
- **Stationary**: $k = k(\boldsymbol{d})$ with $\boldsymbol{d} = \mathbf{x} - \tilde{\mathbf{x}}$
  $\Rightarrow$ invariant to translations in $\mathcal{X}$: $k(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x} + \boldsymbol{d}) = k(\mathbf{0}, \boldsymbol{d})$
- **Isotropic**: $k = k(\boldsymbol{r})$ with $r = \|\mathbf{x} - \tilde{\mathbf{x}}\|$
  $\Rightarrow$ invariant to rotations of $\mathcal{X}$
- Isotropy implies stationarity
- **Dot product**: $k = k(\mathbf{x}^T \tilde{\mathbf{x}})$

CONSTANT KERNEL

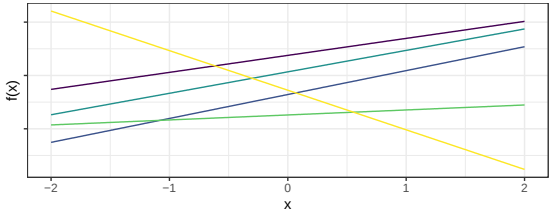
- $k(\mathbf{x}, \tilde{\mathbf{x}}) = \theta_0 \quad > 0$
- Constant function priors
- Global correlation irresp of concrete inputs $\mathbf{x}, \tilde{\mathbf{x}}$
- Use for: global-effect models

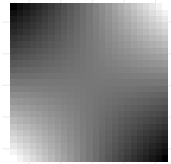


LINEAR KERNEL



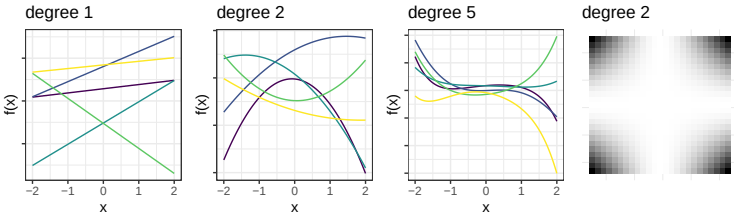
- $k(\mathbf{x}, \tilde{\mathbf{x}}) = \theta_0 + \mathbf{x}^T \tilde{\mathbf{x}}$
- Linear function priors
- Measures directional similarity: higher if vectors point in similar dirs
- In general, non-stationary $\Rightarrow$ depends on absolute location of $\mathbf{x}, \tilde{\mathbf{x}}$
- Use for: linear models





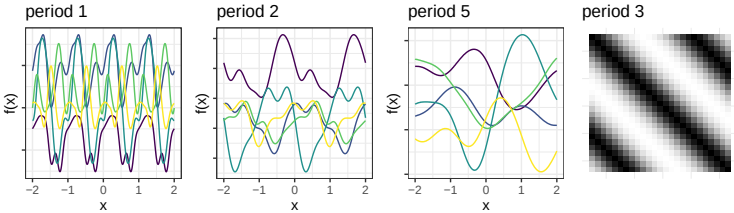
POLYNOMIAL KERNEL

- $k(\mathbf{x}, \tilde{\mathbf{x}}) = (\theta_0 + \mathbf{x}^T\tilde{\mathbf{x}})^p, \quad p \in \mathbb{N}$
- Polynomial function priors
- Allows for non-linearity through higher-order monomials & interaction terms
- Use for: polynomial trends



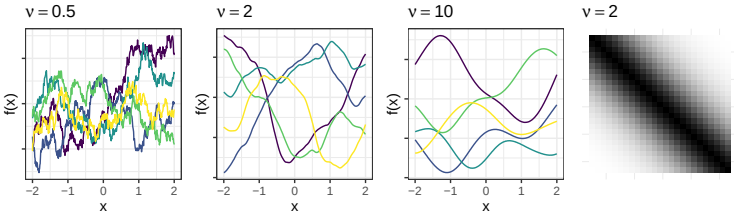
PERIODIC KERNEL

- E.g., $k(\mathbf{x}, \tilde{\mathbf{x}}) = \exp\left(\frac{-2\sin^2(\pi\|\mathbf{x}-\tilde{\mathbf{x}}\|/m)}{\ell^2}\right)$
- m: period, ℓ: length-scale
- Implements idea that $\mathbf{x}$ should be similar to $\mathbf{x} + m$, similarity decaying quadratically in ℓ
- Use for: periodic trends



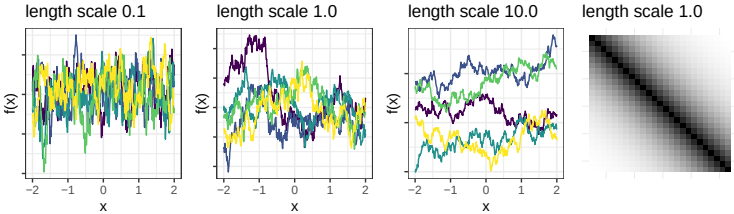
MATÉRN KERNEL

- $k(\mathbf{x}, \tilde{\mathbf{x}}) = \frac{1}{2^\nu \Gamma(\nu)} \left(\sqrt{2\nu}\frac{\|\mathbf{x}-\tilde{\mathbf{x}}\|}{\ell}\right)^\nu K_\nu \left(\sqrt{2\nu}\frac{\|\mathbf{x}-\tilde{\mathbf{x}}\|}{\ell}\right)$
- ν: smoothness param, Γ: gamma function, ℓ: length scale, K_ν: modified Bessel function
- Stationary & isotropic
- Allows for controlled degree of smoothness via choice of ν
- ν also determines differentiability
- Use for: non-linear trend with desired degree of smoothness



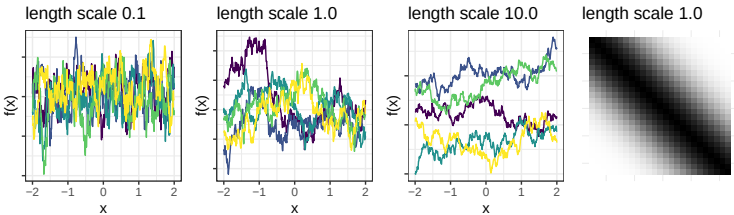
EXPONENTIAL KERNEL

- Aka Ornstein-Uhlenbeck kernel
- $k(\mathbf{x}, \tilde{\mathbf{x}}) = \exp\left(-\frac{\|\mathbf{x}-\tilde{\mathbf{x}}\|}{\ell}\right)$
- Special case of Matérn kernel with $\nu = 0.5$
- Non-smooth: continuous but not differentiable
- Cov decays exponentially with distance (dep on ℓ)
- Use for: non-linear trend with abrupt variations



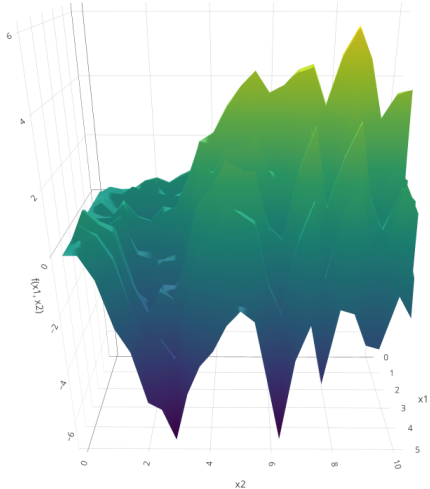
SQUARED EXPONENTIAL KERNEL

- Aka Gaussian kernel, RBF kernel
- $k(\mathbf{x}, \tilde{\mathbf{x}}) = \exp\left(-\frac{\|\mathbf{x}-\tilde{\mathbf{x}}\|^2}{2\ell^2}\right)$
- Special case of Matérn kernel with $\nu = \infty$
- Very smooth: continuous, ∞ differentiable (not always realistic)
- Cov decays quickly $\Rightarrow$ quadratic in ℓ
- Use for: smooth, non-linear trend



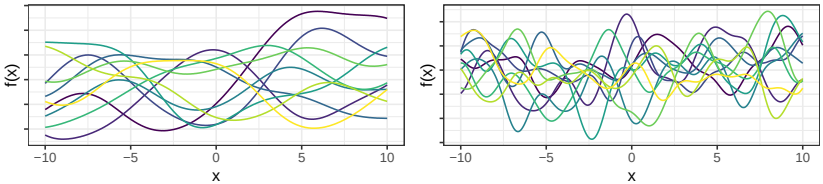
NON-STANDARD KERNELS

- Example: 2D Brownian motion
- Physics application: random fluctuations of particles
- $f \sim \mathcal{GP}(\mathbf{0}, k(\cdot,\cdot))$ with $k(\mathbf{x}, \tilde{\mathbf{x}}) = \min(\mathbf{x}, \tilde{\mathbf{x}})$



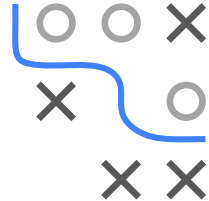
CHARACTERISTIC LENGTH-SCALE

- Key hyperparameter of many (isotropic) kernels
- Controls how quickly function values become uncorrelated
- High (low) ℓ: smooth (wiggly) functions



- Akin to SVM bandwidth but more general: length-scales may vary across input dims

CHOICES FOR CHARACTERISTIC LS



- Reparameterize squared exponential kernel (for $p \geq 2$ dims) as

$$k(\mathbf{x}, \tilde{\mathbf{x}}) = \exp\left(-\tfrac{1}{2}(\mathbf{x} - \tilde{\mathbf{x}})^T \boldsymbol{M}(\mathbf{x} - \tilde{\mathbf{x}})\right)$$

- Possible choices for $\boldsymbol{M}$:

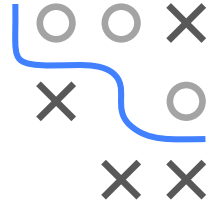
$$\boldsymbol{M}_1 = \ell^{-2}\boldsymbol{I}_p \qquad \boldsymbol{M}_2 = \text{diag}(\boldsymbol{\ell})^{-2} \qquad \boldsymbol{M}_3 = \Gamma\Gamma^T + \text{diag}(\boldsymbol{\ell})^{-2}$$

  where $\boldsymbol{\ell} \in \mathbb{R}_+^p$, $\Gamma \in \mathbb{R}^{p \times k}$

- (Most important) case $\boldsymbol{M}_2$ can also be written as

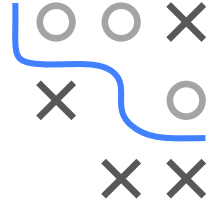
$$k(\boldsymbol{d}) = \exp\left(-\frac{1}{2}\sum_{j=1}^{p}\frac{d_j^2}{\ell_j^2}\right)$$

BENEFITS OF DIM-WISE LENGTH-SCALES

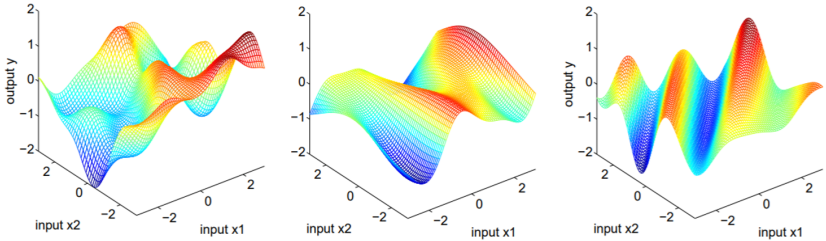


- $\ell_1, \ldots, \ell_p$: characteristic length-scales
- Intuition for ℓ_i: how far to move along i-th axis for fun values to become uncorrelated?
- Implements **automatic relevance determination** (ARD): inverse of ℓ_i determines importance of i-th feature
- Very large $\ell_i \Rightarrow$ cov effectively independent of i-th feature
- For features are on different scales: rescale automatically by estimating $\ell_1, \ldots, \ell_p$

EXAMPLES: CHARACTERISTIC LS



- Left: $\boldsymbol{M} = \boldsymbol{I} \Rightarrow$ same variation in all directions
- Middle: $\boldsymbol{M} = \mathrm{diag}(\boldsymbol{\ell})^{-2} \Rightarrow$ less variation in x_2 direction ($\ell_2 > \ell_1$)
- Right: $\boldsymbol{M} = \Gamma\Gamma^T + \mathrm{diag}(\boldsymbol{\ell})^{-2}$ with $\Gamma = (1, -1)^T$ and $\boldsymbol{\ell} = (6, 6)^T$
  $\Rightarrow \Gamma$ determines dir of most rapid variation



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